

Chapter 99 - Returning Home

Feng Yue and Yan Lin lay on the deck with the sea breeze blowing over them. Feng Yue gazed up at the vast, boundless starry sky, while Yan Lin looked at her.

Actually, after such a long period of psychological preparation, Feng Yue had long since stopped taking her approaching death seriously. After all, she was going to die anyway, and worrying about it would be of no use.

It's just that occasionally thinking about how she would never again be able to accompany the person she loved to explore this world still brought her some small regret.

"When I was little, adults always told us that people become stars in the sky after death. Maybe I'll be up there too someday." Feng Yue's tone was very light, even carrying a hint of barely perceptible interest.

Yan Lin really couldn't bear to hear Feng Yue say such things, but she didn't know how to comfort her either. She could only tightly grasp Feng Yue's hand that hung at her side.

Feng Yue was startled when her hand was suddenly grasped, but after thinking about it, she let her be.

"When you have time in the future, look up and talk to me more often. I probably won't have any friends when I first get up there, and being a lonely star would be quite pitiful." Feng Yue said half-jokingly.

Yan Lin looked at her deeply. Just when Feng Yue thought she would nod, Yan Lin firmly shook her head instead.

"That won't be necessary. You won't become a lonely star."

Feng Yue's expression was stunned, and she couldn't recover for a long time. "You..."

Yan Lin tightened her grip on the warmth in her palm. "Don't think about leaving me behind again."

After Yan Lin finished speaking, she fell silent again and said nothing more. Feng Yue also fell into a dazed quiet.

She was a bit shocked. It wasn't that she hadn't heard Yan Lin say things about following her to death before, but she had never taken those words seriously.

But this time... perhaps because Feng Yue's death was approaching, her heart had loosened considerably, so hearing Yan Lin say this now, she involuntarily believed it somewhat.

Both stopped talking and quietly enjoyed the night sea breeze and the starry sky under the low-hanging night.

How Yan Lin wished time could stop at this moment, so she could forever hold the warm palm of the person beside her.

Time quietly passed. Feng Yue couldn't resist drowsiness and fell into deep sleep lying on the deck chair. As if having some beautiful dream, the corners of her mouth held a faint, barely visible smile.

Yan Lin carefully carried her back to the room and placed her on the bed, then lay down beside Feng Yue and embraced her.

Two streams of fresh orange blossom scent began to overlap and merge, making it impossible to distinguish one from the other for a moment.

The group went ashore early the next morning. There were still two days before their return home, and today was the rest day they had decided on in advance.

Feng Yue wasn't particularly tired, so on this last day she wanted to buy some souvenirs to take back for her friends. Yan Lin naturally went with her.

There were quite a few shops selling small goods on Bali, but many things weren't particularly special. Many even showed signs of originating from some large small-goods market¹ back home, so buying these things wouldn't have much meaning.

So Feng Yue set her sights on shops selling local handmade products.

As soon as Feng Yue and Yan Lin entered a shop, the owner enthusiastically welcomed them. These kinds of handcraft shops generally didn't have very low prices, so there weren't many tourists browsing.

So not only did the owner come forward to greet them, but even a dark-colored cat in the shop wound around Feng Yue's trouser legs.

The owner was a rather well-fed white elderly lady with graying hair neatly pinned back, glasses hanging on her nose bridge, making her whole person appear very spirited.

Feng Yue felt very comfortable as soon as she entered the shop. Combined with a little cat acting coquettishly by her legs with meowing sounds, you'd feel bad not buying something.

So after Feng Yue crouched down to play with the cat for a while, she carefully began selecting items in the shop. The cat rubbed against her for a while before turning back to the depths of the shop.

The shop had quite a lot of things - wooden products and textile products of all kinds, and all handmade.

Feng Yue and Yan Lin browsed around and both picked out things they wanted to buy. Feng Yue's selections were miscellaneous - a bit of everything, while Yan Lin only picked out two small gifts for her parents.

Feng Yue casually looked around once more to see if there was anything else she wanted to buy. With this look, she spotted something on a shelf in the most remote corner of the shop.

As for what it was, Feng Yue could probably only describe it as a pile of twigs, but when she got a bit closer, she could see clearly that it indeed was a pile of twigs, but there was a small light bulb standing in the center of the twigs.

The twigs were mostly about two fingers thick and twenty to thirty centimeters long. These twigs were fixed on a round base, messily arranged in a surrounding pattern that enclosed the light bulb in the center. The light bulb's illumination was very dim - in the well-lit shop, it was quite difficult to see the light it emitted.

Feng Yue looked at this small night light and directly added it to her purchase list.

Yan Lin watched her carrying a clump of twigs back to the front counter to pay, and looked curiously at what was in her hands, but Feng Yue turned her body to directly block Yan Lin's view.

Yan Lin raised an eyebrow and smiled, "What did Ah Yue buy? Can't I see it?"

Feng Yue mumbled an acknowledgment. Yan Lin wanted to tease her more, but was interrupted by faint cat calls from below their feet.

The two looked down and saw that the dark cat seemed to be carrying a dark, living creature in its mouth.

Feng Yue immediately thought of those online videos of cats bringing mice to repay kindness, and exclaimed while jumping onto Yan Lin, "M-mouse!"

Yan Lin was also startled, though not by the cat but by Feng Yue. However, she instinctively reached out to embrace and steadily hold Feng Yue.

Feng Yue was held face-to-face by Yan Lin, with her hands tightly around the person's neck and her legs crossed around the other's waist, then looked down at the little cat with some lingering fear.

The dark little cat was now obediently sitting on the ground, tilting its head to look at these two strange humans in front of it, its crystal-clear blue eyes full of puzzled confusion.

Only then did Yan Lin have time to see what the cat had brought over. After examining it carefully for a while, she smiled and patted Feng Yue's back comfortingly, "Don't be afraid, it's not a mouse. It seems to be this cat's child, a very small kitten."

Hearing this, Feng Yue turned her head and stretched her neck to look down. Sure enough, a little kitten was lying on the ground mewling, though its voice was very small and easily overlooked.

Feng Yue embarrassedly got down from Yan Lin. The cat watched Feng Yue's feet touch the ground, then stretched its neck forward and used its mouth to push the little kitten forward toward Feng Yue, sweetly meowing once.

Feng Yue and Yan Lin exchanged glances, frowning in confusion, "It... what is it doing?"

Yan Lin pondered for a moment, "Hmm, it might have taken a liking to you and wants you to take its child home?"

The two were very puzzled by this, when the owner who had gone to get packaging bags finally returned. Seeing the cat and the little kitten in front of it, she paused for a moment then squinted her eyes and smiled.

"Anna, have you chosen this customer?" The old lady crouched down to rub the cat's head, then stood up to explain to Feng Yue and the others, "Miss, Anna is a child I've been raising. This litter she had three babies total, and this is the last one. Anna has sent away the first two."

Feng Yue understood, "Also to customers?"

The old lady nodded, "The first kitten was given to an elderly couple not long ago, the second one was given to a young lady a week ago. Each time it's Anna personally selecting the caretaker, then entrusting her child to them."

"Of course, if you don't like it or are unwilling, Anna and I won't force you two. You can decide for yourselves."

Hearing this, Feng Yue crouched down and looked at the chubby little kitten in front of her, infinite tenderness rising in her heart.

Feng Yue looked up at Yan Lin and said, "I want to take it home... Mom might need it."

"Alright, we'll take it home."

That settled it. The old lady packed up the little kitten's living supplies and gave them to the two. Until the two left carrying the little kitten, Anna continued squatting at the doorway watching their departing figures.

They didn't go directly back to the boat house, but went to the pet center the old lady had told them about.

The little kitten was currently only two months old and had only received one vaccination. For its safety, it currently couldn't be transported back to the country, so they temporarily placed it at the pet center. When the time came, the pet center staff would help send the kitten on a plane.

Before leaving, Feng Yue was still reluctantly lying by the little kitten's small nest. This was probably the last time she would see the little kitten - when it returned to the country, she might no longer be there.

On the morning of May 1st, the family boarded their return flight. The plane was expected to arrive at Beijing International Airport after eight hours. Around 3 PM, the plane landed.

Yan Lin and Feng He Hai went to the baggage claim to get their luggage, while Feng Yue and Jiang Yu waited for them in place.

However, Feng Yue didn't wait for Yan Lin and her father first, but instead waited for two unexpected people.

"Ah Yue!" As soon as the person saw her, they couldn't wait to call out her name, then walked quickly toward Feng Yue.

Feng Yue looked at the person getting closer and closer, a smile spreading across her face as well, "Sister Wen Zhen! Qiong Qiong!"

Zhou Qiong Qiong came up and gave Feng Yue a big hug, "Welcome home! You stayed abroad way too long this time!"

After Zhou Qiong Qiong released her, Wen Zhen also stepped forward to gently hug her, "How was it? Nothing unexpected happened, right?"

No matter how relaxed Wen Zhen appeared on the surface, she couldn't hide the deep worry in her eyes. She hadn't forgotten about that bucket list².

"Of course not. Being able to go out and have fun to our heart's content occasionally really feels great."

Jiang Yu also knew these two friends of Feng Yue's, so she chatted with them very warmly, with Feng Yue occasionally laughing and adding a sentence or two.

So when Yan Lin and Feng He Hai returned pushing the luggage, what they saw was the scene of several people chatting happily.

Yan Lin's gaze fell on Wen Zhen, who seemed to sense it and also looked up to meet Yan Lin's eyes.

Footnotes:

¹ "Large small-goods market" (某大型小商品市场) - Likely referring to places like Yiwu International Trade City in China, famous for mass-producing inexpensive consumer goods that are exported worldwide.

² "Bucket list" - This refers back to the list of things Feng Yue wanted to do before her predicted death, which Wen Zhen was aware of from earlier in the story.